

HOW THE UNCONSCIOUS INFLUENCES HUMAN BEHAVIOR

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Research paper

We, as the members of St. Andrew's community—students, faculty, administration, and parents – believe in and agree to uphold the values of honesty, equality, trust, and respect. It is our common responsibility to preserve these ideals by our actions.

How much of our behavior and thoughts is truly under our control, and how much is driven by the unconscious? Despite the debate over its credibility and accountability, the unconscious mind significantly influences emotions, reactions and bias. Evidence from culture, psychology, and neuroscience shows how the unconscious mind processes shape the way we experience and respond to the world.

The unconscious is a mental process that occurs outside of conscious awareness and still affects behaviors and emotions. On the other hand, the conscious mind is the main part of the mind, where decisions and emotions are directly felt and made aware of. The difference between the two is that the unconscious functions automatically and outside of our control, yet still influences our behaviors and decisions. As researcher John Bargh explains it, “unconscious mind precede the arrival of a conscious mind-that action precedes reflection.”¹ This means that the unconscious mind’s processes often guide and influence behavior automatically before one has the ability to recognize their response.

To understand what exactly it does and how much of an impact it has on human behavior, first to understand how emotions and decisions are made in the unconscious. Research has shown that people react differently emotionally to hidden signals that they can’t realize, which in turn can uncontrollably influence their behaviors and experiences.² Research that was conducted on Subliminal Emotional Priming, which is

¹ Bargh, John A., and Ezequiel Morsella. "The Unconscious Mind." *Perspectives on Psychological Science*, o.s., 3, no. 1 (2008): 74.

²Bargh and Morsella, 73.

the influence of behavior or emotion through signals that someone is not consciously aware of, shows that barely noticeable or not noticeable emotional cues can influence or change someone's behavior without their conscious feelings. As Piotr Winkelman and Kent Berridge state, “stimuli presented below awareness can elicit an affective reaction that is itself consciously felt.”³ This means that even when a stimulus that evokes an emotional reaction that is too subtle to be consciously recognized, it still can produce a reaction that someone is aware of. By researching and exploring how unconscious emotional cues influence human behavior, one can begin to see how much of our lives are affected by social forces that one isn't aware of.

Some research shows that the unconscious can directly influence perception, emotions, and decisions. For example, one can have reactions to things that people don't consciously notice. An experiment was done by Winkelman and Berridge on perception and emotions, showing participants different emotionally engaging pictures of people to elicit an emotional response. After they were exposed to those images, they reported their conditions and then were given a sour drink, which some participants drank more or less of depending on their experience from looking at the images.⁴ The results indicate that even though they didn't feel any different, their behavior still changed based on what they were experiencing.

Another huge factor of the unconscious is the idea of bias. Tetlock studied unconscious bias, and he came to the conclusion that people can sometimes make decisions based on how they subconsciously feel about a person; for example, it can

³ Winkelman, Piotr, and Kent C. Berridge. "Unconscious Emotion." *Current Directions in Psychological Science* 13, no. 3 (2004): 121.

⁴ Winkelman and Berridge, 122.

affect how they treat or how they perceive someone. These preferences are sometimes not even consciously noticed and aren't even made aware of. This can originate from how one grew up and what they were exposed to or taught early in life.⁵

Some researchers argue that the unconscious doesn't play as much of a role as we think. They argue that it is unclear, hard to understand or study, and isn't separate. One example of this is in Clore's argument, where he talks about how emotions don't count unless we consciously feel them, meaning that if feelings are going on in the background, they might not even be real emotions.⁶ Others also argue that it isn't fair to hold someone accountable for something they can't control or even be aware of. A study by Tetlock found that people felt uncomfortable punishing or judging behavior they weren't aware of.⁷ This brings up the final question: if we can't detect or control it, should we be judged for it?

Researchers have shown that the unconscious mind can trigger emotional reactions based on hidden cues that cannot be consciously interpreted. These reactions happen automatically and have the ability to shape mood, behavior, and attention before the conscious mind can understand or register the change. Bargh and Morsella, in their research, explain that changes in someone's emotional state can be a result of the

⁵ Tetlock, Philip E., Gregory Mitchell, and L. Jason Anastasopoulos. "Detecting and Punishing Unconscious Bias." *The Journal of Legal Studies* 42, no. 1 (2013): 95-96.

⁶ Clore, Gerald L., and Maya Tamir. "Affect as Embodied Information." *Psychological Inquiry* 13, no. 1 (2002): 38. .

⁷ "Detecting and Punishing Unconscious Bias." *The Journal of Legal Studies* 42, no. 1 (2013): 95-100.

environment one is in and the social cues that come along with said environment that never become consciously aware.⁸ This brings up the point of Subliminal emotional priming, which occurs as unconscious cues influence emotion and behavior without awareness; The way it works is that when a person is exposed to emotional information too quickly or subtly that they can't consciously notice but yet still impacts how they behave or feel.⁹ Winkelman and Berridge documented that "under some conditions, people can have subliminal triggered emotional reactions that drive judgement and behavior, even in the absence of any conscious feelings accompanying these reactions."¹⁰

In *The Interpretation of Dreams*, Sigmund Freud who was one of the first researchers to propose that there is an unconscious mind and that it does use impulses and desires to shape how people think and act. He argued that many emotions and desires can be surfaced in disguised forms, especially in dreams.¹¹ This means that the unconscious has the power to shape feelings without our control. Freud also concluded that dreams can show unconscious impulses such as trauma, desires, or stressful things, that express themselves in forms of symbolism or fake scenarios in the dream that would include said impulse.¹² Research since Freud's original theories such as Winkelman and Berridge found that they have the same core idea they are arguing for and it is that emotions and reactions can operate below awareness and yet still guide our actions.

⁸ Bargh and Morsella, 74

⁹ Winkelman and Berridge, 122-123.

¹⁰ Ibid, 121.

¹¹ Sigmund Freud, *The Interpretation of Dreams*, A. A. Brill (New York: Macmillan, 1913), Ch6.

¹² Ibid, ch6.

The unconscious influence of trauma, desires and emotion can impact daily life as well, for example someone who would react strongly to social cues, like you come home and see that your parents aren't in a good mood and you don't realize it but your brain can see it unconsciously through their tone of voice or facial expression, therefore you adjust and you try not to cause problems without realizing it or consciously thinking about it. The reactions he noticed made Freud argue that they are not random but are controlled by suppressed past or present experiences in the unconscious.¹³ Both of the researchers have similar findings in that environmental factors and subliminal cues that cannot be seen consciously can affect emotional states without conscious awareness. With Freud's early psychological theories about the unconscious and current research that is to conducted converge on the fact that emotions are not always going to be a product of deliberate thought, but are more automatic processes that occur in much deeper thought in the unconscious mind.¹⁴

Another example shows that the unconscious can directly influence perception, emotions, and decisions. For example, we can have reactions to things we don't consciously notice. An experiment done by Winkelman and Berridge on perception and emotions in 2003, when they asked participants if they were thirsty, then subliminally showed participants emotional face expressions such as happy, neutral, or angry faces on a projector very fast to the point where they weren't able to consciously recognize the

¹³ Sigmund Freud, *The Interpretation of Dreams*, Ch6

¹⁴ *Ibid*, 75.

different emotions that were displayed. The emotional images were under a pane of glass that had a clearly visible neutral face in the middle, which covered the images. The participants' objective was to identify whether a neutral face was male or female.

Afterwards, they rated their emotional experiences and were given a sour lemon-lime beverage to see what kind of reaction they would produce. The ones who were exposed to happy faces on the projection drank more of the sour beverage than those who were exposed to angry faces, even though the participants didn't report feeling happier or angrier afterwards.¹⁵ The way that this experiment demonstrated Subliminal Emotional Priming is that there were subtle emotional cues that were too quick to be consciously processed, but could still alter their behavior. Winkelman and Berridge explain that "positive and negative reactions can be elicited subliminally and remain inaccessible to introspection," meaning that the participant's ability to consume changed based on the emotion they were exposed to, without their conscious awareness that their ability or behavior had changed.¹⁶ Their study also connects to broader theories, such as Freud's, on how the unconscious influences psychological response. This supports the idea that automatic unconscious processes are able to change or guide physical behaviors even in such a minor way, such as the ability to consume or thirst, depending on your unconscious experience.¹⁷ They support this idea in their results by stating that unconscious reactions have the ability to "drive the person's behavior and psychological reactions, even while remaining inaccessible to conscious awareness."¹⁸ This connects to

¹⁵ Tetlock, Mitchell, and Anastasopoulos. 95-100

¹⁶ Winkelman and berridge, 120.

¹⁷ Ibid, 120-24.

¹⁸ Ibid, 120.

the earlier example about unconsciously reading the room and understanding how to act is similar here, where physical traits such as willingness to consume are changed through an unconscious process that makes your body change depending on what you're experiencing so more stress or negativity will make you more inclined to eat less, drink less, or interact less while a happy mood will do the opposite and make you be willing to eat, drink, and interact even if you aren't consciously aware of the reason you're mood has changed. The results from this experiment show that even if people believe they are acting or experiencing based on conscious decisions, the unconscious still can change or guide their behavior without them feeling different or noticing. This experiment was meant to show that there are emotional cues hidden behind conscious awareness that play a role in how the brain perceives the environment.

A strong and prevalent concept of the unconscious is the idea of bias. This type of process is one that involves automatic judgments or preferences that occur outside of our conscious judgment, meaning that you may be biased towards someone or something without even noticing. These biases are usually based on a few things; more often than not, it's on race, gender, age, religion, or appearance, but it could also be on deeper things such as their origins, politics, wealth, or other factors.¹⁹ These are absorbed from the culture and environment rather than conscious belief. Some people argue that they believe in equality and fairness to all, but the subconscious may still have

¹⁹ Greenwald, Anthony G., and Linda Hamilton Krieger. "Implicit Bias: Scientific Foundations." *California Law Review* 94, no. 4 (2006): 948-50.

experiences and associations that guide decisions and interactions. The primary problem with unconscious bias is that it is mostly invisible and is challenging to detect, since someone might not even realize they are acting unfairly towards someone else, which makes this a difficult idea to detect or correct, since you can't just accuse someone of bias without the proper evidence. A study done by Tetlock and Mitchell looked into how the public perceives and understands responsibility for unconscious bias. They found that there is a "substantial concern about people penalizing unconscious bias at the individual level and that it will be difficult to generate broad support."²⁰ Participants in this study were asked whether or not it was fair to punish or judge someone based on actions or emotions they weren't even aware of. Most of the participants responded negatively to the question, expressing that they were uncomfortable with accusing or punishing someone for something they couldn't control or weren't aware of, even if the type of bias was harmful, such as racism.²¹ This experiment brings to light the ethical problem of if people are unaware of their biases, how are they supposed to be held accountable for said biases? As Tetlock and Mitchell explain, "it will be harder to justify a punitive stance toward people who have yet to do anything wrong-and harder still to justify such a stance."²² This experiment also showed that people recognize the existence of unconscious bias, but are not sure how to read it or determine what its moral or legal consequences are.

Unconscious bias is not just a theory; it really does impact your day-to-day decisions in different ways. It could shape the way decisions are made from job

²⁰ Ibid, 83.

²¹ Ibid, 95-6.

²² Ibid, 87.

interviews to courtroom rulings to police interactions, unconscious judgment can influence the way others are treated. Bargh and Morsella, in their research, explain that “unconscious behavioral guidance systems-perceptual, evaluative, and motivational.”²³ For example, an evaluation of someone's race, including bias, could change factors about the interaction, such as facial expressions, tone of voice, or posture, which can escalate the situation. Even if someone says they're committed to helping others and treating them fairly, they may still have associations that were created in the past through their years of experience with stereotypes or cultural norms. Tetlock and his team did find a way to predict or measure unconscious bias by using a test called the IAT, or implicit association test, given to potential employees or legal staff to make sure there aren't any problematic biases.²⁴ The continued effect of unconscious bias, even in those who reject prejudice, shows that the unconscious can override conscious values or morals. While raising awareness of it is a good starting point, actual change is a lot more difficult since it requires understanding your unconscious roots of judgment and working to stop or change them. Until then, unconscious bias will continue to influence behavior underneath awareness, even if retributive punishment is uncomfortable.

Many researchers argue that the unconscious mind does, in fact, have an influence on behavior, however, some researchers argue about how much it really

²³ Bargh and Morsella, 74.

²⁴ Tetlock, Mitchell, and Anastasopoulos 84-85

matters or how much of it is actually impactful. Clore and Tamir both argued that emotions must be consciously felt in order for them to count as real emotions, and also argued that researchers should be careful with their results to not make them seem greater than they are.²⁵ As Clore states, “emotional expressions play a role in the social consequences of affect by conveying affective information to others.”²⁶ This means that without conscious awareness, the emotions might lose their validity. They also suggested that unconscious reactions, like an increase in heartbeat or tension, may not count as a real reaction or real emotion if a person does not notice it. From their perspective, not all automatic reactions are of the same magnitude as a real emotional experience. Tetlock's research on bias also has some ethical questions to it worth considering, he found that people are uncomfortable with punishing another person for actions based on their unconscious bias, since it's hard to know how to tell the difference and the line between them.²⁷ He states in his research that “The harm principle: virtually no one was ready to abandon that principle and endorse punishing individuals for unconscious attitudes per se.”²⁸ This backs up the idea since it shows how moral accountability for something they can't control is difficult for people to come around to. If you cannot separate or differentiate between them, big claims about what it can do get a little complicated. Even though these are great points to bring up, they don't completely take away from the evidence we already have on unconscious influence. In Winkelman and Berridge's experiment, subliminally exposed participants' behavior changed. They drank more or

²⁵ Clore and Tamir. 38.

²⁶ *Ibid*, 37.

²⁷ Tetlock, Mitchell, and Anastasopoulos 83-85

²⁸ *Ibid*, 104.

less of a sour drink based on emotional reactions they didn't know they had seen, and their actions had changed even when they felt no different.²⁹ This proves that there are emotional cues that can guide behavior without a controlling feeling. While Clore and Tamir are right about researchers being more careful, the evidence from experiments still shows that the unconscious still influences human behavior. The reality of these emotions or feelings they mention is that they may not seem obvious, but they do have a measurable effect that allows them to be studied. In those studies done it shows that the unconscious still has an effect on how we act, feel, or think.

In conclusion, the unconscious mind is not a hidden process that has the ability to occasionally change or interfere with our lives, but instead it is a constant, automatic guide that subtly influences our behavior and actions. Through many decades of research and experiments, we now know that unconscious processes are more deeply involved in our day-to-day lives than before. Now we understand how they can shape our emotions, behavior, and social dynamics. From subliminal cues that have the ability to influence your mood, your ability to drink, and more, to biases that can silently cause judgment, outside of our conscious awareness. One of the clearest ways that the subconscious can be seen is through our emotional reactions. Since these hidden processes happen so fast that they have the ability to completely bypass conscious thought and awareness. As Bargh put it, "We are often guided by our feelings, intuitions, and gut reactions."³⁰ meaning that unconscious impulses are often what's impacting our feelings, but also our

²⁹ Winkelman and Berridge, 120-22.

³⁰ Bargh and Morsella, 76.

physical responses as well. Subliminal emotional cues, as Winkelman and Berridge's research was conducted, they found that even without a reported change in conscious emotion, "Participants were still thirsty, specifically, thirsty participants poured significantly more drink from the pitcher and drank more from their cup after happy faces than sad faces."³¹ This shows that subliminal cues have the ability to still influence our actions that we believe at the time are deliberate. More complex issues, such as unconscious bias and the issues associated with it. People may think that they are acting fair, but in reality, they could be acting unfairly without their conscious realization. This is because of judgments or associations created by past experiences and cultural exposure.³² This gives a reason for how seemingly unnoticeable or small influences that have happened over the course of one's life have such a large effect on some aspects of life, a few examples of which are job interviews, policing interactions, etc. Whether through subtle bias, automatic reactions, or instinctual reactions, the unconscious mind lurks around and quietly governs more of our lives than one realizes or likes to admit. It is far peripheral, the unconscious is a major force that silently dictates every day life through the influence of culture, experience, and bias. Evidence from decades of research shows that it does have an impact even as so small as changing that flavor or tolerance of a drink therefore meaning that despite its credibility and accountability the unconscious mind influences who one is.

³¹ Winkelman and Berridge, 122.

³² Ibid, 74-76.

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